

Image 8.1: Roads through Aksai Chin Area in 1953
Source: Archives of AIM Television Pvt. Ltd.

China Encroaches into Ladakh

The report also reveals that another PLA regiment was stationed on the Tibetan side of the Tibet-Ladakh border, near Koyul in the Indus Valley. According to the US document, the 2 Cavalry's Commandant announced the Chinese intention to build new roads in the area. The planned roads would run from Rutok to Keriya, south of the Taklamakan Desert in Sinkiang, on the eastern edge of the Aksai Chin. Also planned, was a motorable road from Khotan to Suget Karaul that would end at Vanjilga at the western end of the Aksai Chin. The road from Khotan to Rutok was slated to be completed in June or July 1953. According to Urumchi radio, it was completed on time, said the CIA note. The latter road is clearly what got to be called the Aksai Chin Road, now known as Highway 219. Back